

The Balloon Side Hustle Starter Guide

From your first garland to your first \$500 client. Real numbers from a working studio in London, Canada. Everything we wish someone had told us before the first build.

12 minute read · prices in CAD · your market will vary, the logic will not

I. The honest math, before you buy a single balloon

Here is what a working studio actually charges. A standard organic garland, the eight to twelve foot piece you see behind every dessert table on Pinterest, sells for \$200 to \$500. Small accent garlands start around \$160. Balloon arches run \$299 for a small organic piece to \$999 for a standard ceremony arch, and past \$1,200 when they need a frame built underneath. Table centerpieces go for \$39 to \$139 each, and events order them in sets.

Now the cost side. The materials in a \$300 garland are roughly \$40 to \$60. Balloons, decorating strip, glue dots, a few command hooks. At our studio a \$300 garland is one to two hours all-in, transport and quoting included. Budget double that for your first few builds, because speed is the main thing the reps buy you.

That is the math behind the number on the cover. Four \$300 garlands in a month, one Saturday morning each, is \$1,200 in revenue and roughly \$1,000 after materials. Not a fortune, and not a fantasy either. Four bookings a month in one city is a very reachable bar once the channels in chapter 5 are running.

So the margin is real. It is also the whole game. The \$80 garland kills more side hustles than bad garlands ever will. Price like a hobbyist and you will book every weekend, exhaust yourself, and quit before anyone offers you real money. This guide

keeps coming back to that, because it is the difference between a side hustle and an expensive hobby.

The honest downsides, so you go in clear-eyed: your car will be full of balloons on Saturday mornings. Heat and sun are enemies. Things pop, sometimes in front of the client. People will ask you to work for exposure. All of it is manageable. None of it goes away.

2. The \$150 starter kit

Skip the inventory. One palette and the right tools cover your first paid job. Buy this and nothing else until someone has paid you:

- **Electric balloon inflator, \$40 to \$60.** The one non-negotiable. A dual-nozzle machine turns a two hour inflation session into twenty minutes and saves your wrists for the build.
- **11 inch quality latex balloons, \$25 to \$35 per 100 online.** The body of every garland. Order pro-grade latex ahead of time, because the party-store equivalent costs more and performs worse.
- **5 inch latex balloons, \$10 to \$15 per 100.** The filler size that makes a garland look professional instead of lumpy. The pros-versus-beginners difference is mostly the small balloons.
- **Balloon decorating strip, \$8 to \$12 a roll.** The plastic spine you push balloon necks through. This is the entire structural secret of a garland.
- **Glue dots, \$5 to \$8.** For sticking 5 inch balloons into the gaps.
- **A hand pump, about \$8.** For topping up and for the 5 inch balloons the machine overinflates.
- **Command hooks, fishing line, and a couple of weights, about \$20 total.** How garlands attach to walls you are not allowed to drill.

That is roughly \$115 to \$160. Where to source it: the latex and the decorating strip come from balloon-specific online wholesalers, not the party store, because pro-grade 11 inch latex at \$25 to \$35 per 100 beats thin party latex on price and lifespan at the same time. The inflator and the weights are the two items worth buying used. Dual-nozzle inflators show up on local marketplace listings from people who quit, and anything under \$40 that powers on both nozzles is a good deal, since there is

very little inside one to break. Never buy used balloons though. Latex ages in the bag, and you cannot see it until the build pops.

And here are the two purchases beginners waste money on, so you can skip both: party-store balloon assortments, because mixed-colour bags of thin latex oxidize fast, pop early, and photograph badly, and a helium tank, because the installs that make money are air-filled. Buy *one* palette of two or three colours instead of a rainbow. Every colour in a build is a separate inflation batch and a separate sort, which is a pricing lesson you may as well learn at the checkout.

3. Your first three builds, in this exact order

Build one: a garland. The garland is the base unit of everything in this trade. An arch is a garland on a frame. A backdrop is garlands at scale. Inflate your 11 inch balloons to slightly different sizes on purpose, thread them through the strip in clusters, then glue-dot 5 inch balloons into every gap until no strip shows. Do it on your own wall. Photograph it in daylight. That photo is the start of your portfolio.

Build two: an arch. Same skill plus structure. Start with a half arch that climbs one side of a doorway and stops, it costs less, forgives more, and often photographs better than a full arch. Learn what wind does before you ever promise an outdoor arch. Full sun turns latex chalky in hours and heat expands the air until balloons pop, which is why pros underinflate slightly and chase shade for outdoor work.

Build three: a backdrop. Scale, and the sizing trap. An eight foot wide backdrop covers one or two people in a photo. Group shots need ten to twelve feet, because a row of six guests is wider than it looks and a backdrop that ends behind someone's shoulder is what you notice in every picture afterward. Size to the camera, not to the wall. While you are at it, learn the centerpiece rule: anything taller than fourteen inches on a dining table blocks the person across it, and guests will quietly move your work out of their way.

One material fact that surprises everyone: helium is mostly irrelevant. Latex helium floats eight to twelve hours, which is why serious installs are air-filled. Air-filled work holds for days or weeks, can go up the night before, and never needs a tank rental.

Past these three builds, the skill ladder is reps on purpose. Recreate one saved Pinterest build a month in your own palette, because copying a shape you did not design teaches faster than repeating your own. Then learn frames, since a frame under the latex is what separates a \$999 arch from a \$299 one. And every styled shoot you do doubles as practice that someone photographs professionally, which is chapter 5's second channel working for your skills and your portfolio at once.

4. Pricing from day one

Three things move the price of any build, and if you can explain them you can defend any quote without apologizing:

- **Size.** Length for garlands, height and span for arches, coverage for backdrops. A fourteen foot entrance is a different build from a six foot doorway.
- **Colour count.** Every added colour is another inflation batch and another sort before the build starts. Two colours is efficient. Six is a surcharge.
- **The surface and the venue.** Brick, glass, and no-drill rental halls each need different attachment methods. Outdoor adds wind and sun planning. Venues with rules add coordination time.

The floor: never quote below three times your materials. On a \$50-materials garland that is \$150 minimum, and standard market pricing sits comfortably above that. Quote a fixed price for the piece, never an hourly rate, because clients buy the finished thing and getting faster should widen your margin.

And say no early. No to below-cost gigs framed as exposure. No to same-day panic builds you cannot do well. No to the client who wants the \$400 arch for \$150 because it is "just balloons." Every yes to those is a weekend you cannot sell to a real client.

5. Your first 10 customers in the first 4 weeks

Ten customers in four weeks is an aggressive target and a reachable one, because the first ten rarely come from strangers. None of this costs money. Here is the sequence we would run:

Week one: open the doors and tell your own people. Create a Google Business Profile the day you decide to do this. Local search is where "balloon garland near me" turns into a phone call, and the map listing outranks any website you could build. Then build the wall garland from chapter 3, photograph it in daylight, and send that photo to your own circle with one line: you are taking balloon bookings. The first three customers are usually a friend's shower, a coworker's birthday, a cousin's grad party. Do not skip the announcement out of shyness. Our bet: it outbooks every channel below.

Week two: one styled shoot with a local photographer. Photographers need fresh sets the same way you need portfolio photos. Offer the trade: you build, they shoot, both of you post and tag each other. When we offered this in our own city, more than a dozen photographers said yes in a week. One shoot gives you professional photos of your work, which beats months of phone pictures, and puts you in front of their audience of people actively planning events.

Week three: one free community build, chosen coldly. A church fundraiser, a school event, a charity thing, picked because the room is full of people who host the events you want to be hired for. Ask for three things instead of money: a social tag, a review, and a small card next to the install. Our bet, from running this play ourselves: one good community build in front of the right crowd beats a month of posting.

Week four: turn the first jobs into the next ones. Ask every happy client for a Google review, and ask them to name what you built. "The garland was beautiful" helps. "The balloon garland for our shower in [your city] was beautiful" is what search engines index. Post every build to your profile with your city in the caption, because the caption text is what Google reads. And answer the "anyone know someone who does balloons?" posts in your local community groups with a photo instead of a link. That question gets asked every week, and the vendor who shows the work usually gets the message.

6. The framework that brings customers back

Balloon work has a quiet advantage over most side hustles: events repeat. The kid who turned five turns six. The company that launched a product launches another

one. The venue that hosted one shower hosts forty a year. A client kept is a client you never have to find again, so run these four steps on every single job:

- **Ask for the review while they are still smiling.** Same day, one link, and ask them to name the piece and the city in it. A review with "balloon arch" and your city in the text works for you every day afterward.
- **Leave two cards, not one.** One for the client, one for the guest who asked "who did the balloons?" Someone always asks.
- **Write down their next date.** The birthday recurs in twelve months. Message them six weeks ahead: "planning anything for Maya's birthday this year?" It reads as thoughtful because it is, and it lands before they start looking.
- **Treat the venue staff as clients too.** The banquet-hall manager who watched you install clean and leave no mess gets asked for vendor names every week. Leave a card with them on the way out.

Run those four on your first ten jobs and the word spreads without you paying for it. Our bet: within a few months, half your bookings come from this loop instead of from new marketing.

7. Tips and tricks from the jobs that taught us

What to avoid like the plague:

- Below-cost gigs framed as exposure. Exposure does not buy latex.
- Rainbow inventory. Stock one signature palette deep and buy it in bulk, instead of a shelf of colours that each cover half a build.
- Outdoor promises without a weather plan. Full sun turns latex chalky in hours, heat pops overinflated balloons, and wind eats backdrops. Quote outdoor work with shade, underinflation, and a rain plan already in it.
- Same-day panic builds in your first months. A rushed build that pops at the party costs more reputation than the fee was worth.
- Hourly pricing. Clients buy the finished piece. Getting faster should widen your margin, not shrink your invoice.

What to double down on:

- Whatever palette booked twice. That is your signature forming. Deep-stock it and put it all over your profile.
- The photographers who tag you. Every tagged photo is an ad you did not pay for, running to an audience that plans events.
- Business clients. A dealership or an office that books once tends to book quarterly, and one corporate install can pay what a month of birthday garlands does.
- Daylight photos of every build, even the small ones. Your portfolio is the product until your reputation is.

And for keeping momentum once you hit traction: batch your inflation, one session for two jobs saves an hour. Raise your price a step after every five bookings and watch the yes rate, because the calendar filling up is the market telling you the price is low. And protect one weekend a month as off-limits, so the hustle still exists in a year.

8. Three paths past a side hustle

Every booking, from a \$160 garland to a corporate install, runs the same pipeline: qualify the enquiry, quote it, take a deposit, deliver, then ask for the review. The moment you notice yourself typing the same quote message for the third time, that is the business telling you what to systematize first. Templates before tools, tools before hires. From there, three paths open up:

Path one: go premium. Same hours, bigger builds. Raise prices as the calendar fills and move toward weddings and corporate work, where one install can pay what a month of birthday garlands does. This is the path we took at Balloonina, and it is how a solo artist's income can pass a day job without hiring anyone.

Path two: go volume. Keep prices mid-market and add hands. Train a helper on inflation and teardown, run two or three jobs a weekend instead of one, and pay them per job. The ceiling lifts, and so does the coordination work, so this path suits you if you would rather manage than build.

Path three: productize. Sell the thing without the install. Grab-and-go garland kits, porch-drop number displays, workshops where you teach the build to the next wave

of beginners. Lower ticket and no venue hours, and it stacks on top of either path above instead of replacing it.

Whichever path, two rules carry you. Your hours are the ceiling, so when demand fills your calendar the move is raising prices, not adding weekends. And document what works as you go, because a repeatable system is the difference between owning a business and owning a tiring job.

That is the whole start. A \$150 kit, three practice builds, prices you do not apologize for, ten customers in four weeks, and a loop that brings them back. The first \$500 client is closer than it looks from here.

This guide comes from Balloonía Events, a custom balloon studio in London, Canada run by a trained artist. We are documenting the entire playbook of building this studio, the pricing, the systems, the mistakes, as we go. You are on the list, so you will hear about it first.

Brenda & the Balloonía team